

viruses, you'll already be familiar with many of these steps.

1. Be careful downloading files in IM. Never open, accept, or download a file in IM from someone you don't know. If the file comes from someone you do know, don't open it unless you know what the file is and you were expecting it. Contact the sender by e-mail, phone, or some other method to confirm that what they sent was not a virus.
2. Update your Windows software. Visit Windows Update to scan your computer and install any high-priority updates that are offered to you. If you have Automatic Updates enabled, the updates are delivered to you when they are released, but you have to make sure you install them.
3. Make sure you're using an updated version of your IM software. Using the most up-to-date version of your IM software can better protect your computer against viruses and spyware. If you're using MSN Messenger, install the updated version by visiting the MSN Messenger Web site and clicking the 'Download Now!' button.
4. Use anti-virus software and keep it updated. Anti-virus software can help to detect and remove IM viruses from your computer, but only if you keep the antivirus software current. If you've purchased a subscription from an anti-virus software company, your anti-virus software may update itself when you're connected to the Internet.
5. Use anti-spyware software and keep it updated. Some IM viruses may install spyware or other unwanted software on your computer. Anti-spyware software can help to protect your computer from spyware and remove any spyware you may already have. If you don't have anti-spyware software, you can download the new Microsoft Windows AntiSpyware (Beta) or another spyware removal tool.